

SOUTHERN LATITUDES

THE STARS

A rich band of constellations can be seen across the sky, from southwest to northeast, along the path of the Milky Way. Crux (the Southern Cross) and Centaurus (the Centaur) are in the southwest, to the right of the celestial meridian. The lesser-known constellations Lupus, Norma, and Triangulum Australe are on the meridian. Ruddy Antares (see p.256) is overhead, with the curving tail of Scorpius, the Scorpion, extending to the southeast. Next to its tail are the dense star fields of Sagittarius in the Milky Way. Along the Milky Way to the east is Altair (see p.252) in the constellation Aquila, while Vega (see p.253) is low in the northeast. Arcturus and Spica are high in the northwest.

DEEP-SKY OBJECTS

Heading away from Scorpius and toward the Milky Way and the center of the galaxy, two magnificent open star clusters, M6 and M7, are positioned near the end of the Scorpion's tail. Both clusters are visible to the naked eye, and they appear

THE SCORPION'S LAIR

Orange-red Antares, the star at the heart of Scorpius, and the curved line of stars marking the Scorpion's tail are distinctive sights in June skies. Hovering over the "sting" in the tail are two prominent star clusters, M6 and M7 (bottom left).

magnificent through binoculars. M7 is the larger and brighter of the two; it appears twice the width of a full moon. Another prominent open cluster in Scorpius is NGC 6231, positioned next to Zeta (ζ) Scorpii.

The globular cluster Omega (ω) Centauri, or NGC 5139, and the peculiar galaxy NGC 5128, or Centaurus A, remain well placed for observation this month, as do the Coalsack Nebula and the Jewel Box Cluster (see p.264), in Crux, and the spiral galaxy M83 (in the constellation Hydra).

